A Thousand Acres

by Jane G. Smiley

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Incest is a tragedy of enormous proportions, with repercussions that are often far-reaching.*

ACTRESS 2: *Children who are sexually abused by a family member rely on creating coping mechanisms in order to survive*

ACTRESS 1: *As adults, these coping patterns can get in the way of having a full and healthy life.*

ACTRESS 2: *In A Thousand Acres by Jane G. Smiley, the abuse two sisters lived through as teenagers shadow their adult lives.*

ACTRESS 1: *Rose, married and now a mother of two girls, has become hard and angry.*

ACTRESS 2: *Ginny, also married, is stuck in peace-making inertia, perpetually afraid, uncertain and empty.*

ACTRESS 1: *In this scene, the sisters finally discuss their childhood experiences and come up with a plan to confront their father.*

TOGETHER: *A Thousand Acres by Jane G. Smiley*

FOR EDU

ROSE: Sometimes I hate him. Sometimes waves of hatred just roll through me, and I want him to die, and go to hell and stay there forever, just roasting!

GINNY: Rose!

ROSE: Why are you saying "*Rose!*" in that shocked way? Because you're not supposed to wish evil on someone or because you don't really hate him?

GINNY: I don't, I really don't. He's a *bear*, but --

ROSE: He's not a bear. He's not innocent like that.

GINNY: *(raising voice)* Last night I told him in no uncertain terms that if he drove drunk again, I'd take the truck keys away from him. He heard me, too. He was looking right at me. I think things'll improve. He's hard to live with --

ROSE: Sometimes I hate you too…I hate you because you're the link between me and him.

GINNY: Who?

ROSE: *(throwing up hands in exasperation)* Daddy, of course! Don't be so stupid you're such a good daughter…so slow to judge, it's like stupidity. It drives me crazy!

GINNY: *(smiling)* Just last night, I was thinking the same thing about Ty -- last night.

ROSE: Every time I've made up my mind to do something—get off this place, leave Pete, go back to teaching just to earn the money—you stop me. When I was little, I mean really little, three or four, you were like this wall between me and him, but now you're the path, you don't keep him out, you show him the way in, every time you're reasonable, every time you pause to wonder about his point of view. Every time you stop and think! I don't want to stop and think! *(pushes hair back and puts fist on hip, defiant)*

GINNY: I'm not like him. I don't always sympathize with him. But I can't say I have any faith that he's going to meet us halfway. I think it's practical to try and work around him sometimes. Anyway, the point is, yes, you're right, I've let him get away with a lot of stuff. We all have. But we can set rules, and I think the rules can be pretty simple. *(Long pause)*

ROSE: Ginny? Tell me what you really think about Daddy

GINNY: Well, I don't know. I love Daddy. But he's so in the habit of giving orders, no back talk. You know. "I mean, he drinks and everything. I don't know how that colors things. I'm willing to admit that he's been drinking a long time, probably as long as we've known him. I haven't really thought about it, but I'm sure if we sat down and worked it out—

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ROSE: *(stares at her sister)*

GINNY: Rose, you're making me nervous. What do you want me to say? "I mean, Mommy hasn't been around to tell us what to think of Daddy. I wonder about whether they were happy. Whether she liked him. Or he liked her. Though everybody liked Mommy. I think different things.

ROSE: *(clears throat)* Shit Ginny, *(Ginny laughs; Rose rolls her eyes . . . . long pause)* I don't hate you. I know what I was saying, but I don't know what it means, exactly. Or how to tell you what it means. Or something. Let's say the real story here is what you think. He's a pain in the butt, we divvy up the work. Maybe rules will do the trick. We can try it. United front, right?

GINNY: Right.

ROSE: I used to fantasize that Mommy had escaped and taken an assumed name, and someday she would be back for us. You want to hear the life I had picked out for us?

GINNY: Sure.

ROSE: She was a waitress at the restaurant of a nice hotel, and we lived with her in a Hollywood-style apartment, you know, its own door, two floors, two bedrooms and a bathroom up and living room and kitchen down. Nice shag carpeting, white walls, little sounds from the neighbors on either side, sliding door out to the back deck. There had to be neighbors on both sides. I thought it would be scary to live on the end.

GINNY: I guess I never really thought about not living on the farm. Isn't that funny? I wanted it to be different, though, in some ways.

ROSE: Ginny you sound so…*mild*…Aren't you furious?

GINNY: What good is that? We still have to deal with it. [Daddy's] always had rages, I admit.

ROSE: Ginny, you don't remember how he came after us, do you?

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GINNY: I remember the shoe incident. I was remembering that when he was yelling at me, the way he made Mommy -

ROSE: I don't mean when we got strapped or spanked.

GINNY: Came after us?

ROSE: When we were teenagers. How he came into our rooms.

GINNY: *(licking lips and fidgeting)* We slept together while Mommy was sick.

ROSE: And then, that Christmas, we moved into separate rooms. He said it was time we had separate rooms.

GINNY: Well, of course I remember having separate rooms. I don't remember why.

ROSE: He went into your room at night.

GINNY: What for? I don't remember that at all.

ROSE: How can you not remember? You were fifteen years old!

GINNY: I'm sure I was asleep. Grandpa Cook used to prowl around looking at everybody. It was like checking the hogs or something.

ROSE: It wasn't like *checking the hogs* with Daddy.

GINNY: What are you saying, Rose?

ROSE: You know.

GINNY: I promise you I don't know.

ROSE: *(Inhales, holds breath, then exhales)* He was having sex with you.

GINNY: He was not!

ROSE: I saw him go in! He stayed for a long time!

GINNY: Times always seem longer in the middle of the night. He was probably closing the windows, or something. *(concillatory)*

ROSE: I checked my clock.

GINNY: Oh, Rose! How am I going to believe that you woke up twenty-one years ago and saw Daddy come into my room and checked your clock and then saw him come out

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and checked your clock and that constitutes evidence that he was - Anyway Daddy might be a drinker and even a rager, but he goes to church…

ROSE: It's true. *(voice is low, demanding belief)* He threatened you. He made sure you wouldn't tell me. He said if you told me, I'd be really jealous, and wouldn't like you any more. You were fifteen. You didn't have much spunk. You believed that.

GINNY: But it didn't happen.

ROSE: But it did.

GINNY: Well, why don't I remember? Do you think I'm lying?

ROSE: That's the way it happened with me. *(flat affect)*

GINNY: What?

ROSE: Because, after he stopped going in to you, he started coming in to me, and those are the things he said to me, and that's what we did. We had sex in my bed.

GINNY: You were thirteen!

ROSE: …and fourteen…and fifteen…and sixteen.

GINNY: I don't believe it!

ROSE: I thought you knew. I thought all these years you and I shared this knowledge, sort of underneath everything else. I thought if after that you could go along and treat him normally the way you do, then it was okay to just put it behind us.

GINNY: What about Caroline?

ROSE: *(long pause)* I'm not sure. I mean, he told me that if I went along with him, he wouldn't get interested in her. He presented it as a kind of biological fact. I suspect he never tried anything with her, mostly because she acts like she feels differently toward him than we do. She humors him and sympathizes with him. He doesn't overwhelm her the way he does us.

GINNY: But he doesn't overwhelm you! You stand right up to him?

ROSE: He liked that. All those dates and escapes when I was in high school? It made him think he had to subdue me. He liked it.

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GINNY: You sound like you were trying to keep him interested!

ROSE: Well, I was afraid he'd try something with Caroline, and she was only eight or ten. But I was flattered, too. I thought that he'd picked me, me, to be his favorite, not you, not her. On the surface, I thought it was okay, that it must be okay if he said it was, since he was the rule maker. He didn't rape me, Ginny. He seduced me. He said it was okay, that it was good to please him, that he needed it, that I was special. He said he loved me.

GINNY: I can't listen to this

ROSE: And why I send them to boarding school. Though it gave me a little shiver, having him driving all over, down to Des Moines and everything. I'm not sure the school would prevent them from going out with him.

GINNY: Has he ever . . .

ROSE: Not that I know of. I bought the books, and we went through all the drills and stuff. I prepared them without mentioning Daddy. And I've kept my eyes peeled. And we were in our teens.

GINNY: It didn't happen to me, Rose. I don't know what to say! This is ridiculous! I mean, the strangest thing is how idiotic I feel, how naïve and foolish. God, I am so sorry he did that.

ROSE: Don't make me feel sorry for myself. That's the hardest. The more pissed off I am, the better I feel.

GINNY: Okay. Okay. Okay. I don't understand Daddy. I just don't

ROSE: *(angry)* I understand him perfectly. You're making it too complicated. It's as simple as a child's book. I want, I take, I do.

GINNY: That's not enough for me. I can't believe it's that simple. We're his children!

ROSE: I'm telling you, if you try to understand, it just holds you back. You start seeing things from his point of view and you're just paralyzed. That was his

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goddamed hold over me, Ginny! For all those years! He talked. He made me see things from his point of view! He needed someone! He needed me! He loved me. Ginny, you don't want to understand it, or imagine it. You don't . . . you don't . . . you don't.

GINNY: We've got to talk to him about it . . . .

ROSE: He won't get away with it, Ginny. I won't let him get away with it. I just won't. I know that his face is a black ocean and there's always, always, always the temptation to drown in that ocean, to just give yourself up and sink. You've got to stare back. You've got to remind yourself what he is, what he does, what he did. We have to stand up to that. Until there's true remorse. Nothing will be right until there's that. He's got to repent and feel humiliation and regret. I won't be satisfied until he knows what he is.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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